Football Officials' Pregame Conference Guide

The Pregame Conference is mandatory for all Varsity games and should begin at least 90 minutes before scheduled kickoff.

Officials should not be dressing or otherwise engaged in other activities; all officials should give full attention to the Pregame Conference.

Section 1 | Administrative

❑ Crew Health & Readiness

- Ensure that all Crew members are healthy and ready to work
  - ✓Discussed adjustments should a Crew member have an acceptable limitation.
  - ✓Review how Crew will adjust to illness / injury during the game.

❑ Timing

- Synchronize watches to correct time; verify kickoff time and length of half-time
  - ✓ Half-time; Crew to meet at a designated place on the field
  - ✓ Wait for teams to leave the field; R starts the halftime clock

Section 1 | Administrative

- **Timing**
  - Review procedures for loss of scoreboard clock and/or game score
  - Starting/stopping clock; any official may stop the clock; only R can start the clock
  - 25 second count; BJ in five-man; R otherwise

Section 1 | Administrative

- **Timeouts**
  - Team Timeout (TO); regulation and overtime
  - Injury / Heat / Weather
  - Officials' TO
  - Coach / Referee Conference procedures; Wing Official to monitor
    - ✓ Coach / Referee Conference will cost a Team timeout
  - Who times TO? BJ in five-man; R otherwise
  - All officials maintain a record of timeouts; verify TO remaining after each time out; Wing Officials advise Coaches of TO remaining

Section 1 | Administrative

- **Changes/Bulletins**
  - Review Rules and/or Mechanics changes for the current season
  - Review weather bulletins as appropriate

Section 1 | Administrative

- **Bench Management**
  - Review expectations and bench management process
  - Consistent on both sidelines; Coaches on / off the field
  - Review differences between "Sideline Interference" and "Unsportsmanlike Conduct"
  - Wing Official to identify and use a "Get-Back Coach“
  - Potential penalty enforcements
  - Game expectations
    - ✓Review any pertinent history relevant to players' and/or coaches' attitudes and behaviors

Section 1 | Administrative

- **Special Coverage**
  - "Hurry-up Offense" / "No Huddle Offense"
  - On-Side Kicks
  - "Use of the Bean Bag;"
  - Mercy Rule (if you have it, Oklahoma only has it in 8-man)
  - Skirmishes, fights, etc.
  - Weather threats or interruptions; e.g., lightning

Section 1 | Administrative

❑ Making the Call

- The Halo Principle;
- Review "dead-ball officiating" practices;
- Review pre-snap signals; e.g., on/off the line, double stakes, etc.
- Counting players; Offense? Defense? Signals?
- Remember good eye-contact

Section 1 | Administrative

❑ Calling / Reporting / Recording Fouls

- See Philosophies & Guidelines;
- Player safety is primary
- Fair play; did the player's action(s) impact the play?
- If you have cautioned a player, let his Coach know.

Section 1 | Administrative

❑ Calling / Reporting / Recording Fouls

- Proper penalty report:
  - ✓ Status of the ball; e.g., live/dead, loose/during the run, etc.
  - ✓ Offending player; e.g., "Number 67“
  - ✓ Offending team; e.g., offense/defense or color?
  - ✓ Foul & result of the play
- Wing Officials reminded to notify their Coach regarding nature of the infraction, number of the penalized player, and any special enforcement; e.g., loss of down, untimed down, etc.
- Calling Official records all major fouls (10+ yards) he/she calls

Section 2 | Pregame Duties

❑Coaches' Meeting

- Crew takes the field together 30 — 45 minutes prior to kickoff
- Meet with Home Team Coach first
- Crew Introductions
  - ✓ Provide Coaches with a printed list of Officials

Section 2 | Pregame Duties

❑ Coaches' Meeting

- Questions for the Coaches
  1. "Do you have any questions regarding the Rules changes for this season?”
  2. "Do you have a Get Back Coach?“
  3. "Are all your players properly equipped?“
  4. "Do any of your players have a cast or splint?" (For inspection by U)
  5. "Do you have any planned trick plays or unusual formations?“
  6. "Do you understand the restrictions we will enforce on bench/sideline behavior?“
  7. "Do you have any special concerns about this game?""What are the numbers/names of your Captains?"

Section 2 | Pregame Duties

❑ Coaches' Meeting

- Questions for the Coaches
  8. "Are your QB's and/or Kickers right/left handed/ footed?“
  9. "Do you kick extra points or do you go for 2?“
  10. "Who will call timeouts from your sideline?“
  11. "Who are your ball persons?"

Section 2 | Pregame Duties

- ❑ **Coaches' Meeting**
  - Review the timing and process for the coin toss and kickoff
  - Confirm the length of half-time
  - Review requirements for having the Team on the field
    - ✓At least 3 minutes prior to kickoff.
    - ✓For the full 3-minute warm-up period following half-time.

Section 2 | Pregame Duties

❑ Crew Duties

- R: Inspect the field (inside the sidelines), pylons, goalposts and goalpost padding; approve the game balls
- U: Spot-check players for uniform violations and proper equipment
- HL: Inspect the down box and chains; ensure proper length and tape at midway point; meet with and instruct the Chain Crew
- LJ: Inspect the field (outside the sidelines), pylons, goalposts and goalpost padding; meet with the ball persons (Crew of 4)
- BJ: Meet with the ball persons (Crew of 5); ensure coverage behind the goalposts following a field goal attempt or an extra point try

Section 2 | Pregame Duties

- **Crew Duties**
  - After completion of these inspections and meetings, Crew should casually observe both teams, note wind and weather conditions, kickers' abilities, etc.; then exchange any pertinent information with other members of the crew.

Section 3 | Coin Toss

- **Logistics**
  - Occurs 3 minutes prior to kickoff; .9) | (Start process at 5 minutes prior)
  - U & BJ (with Visitors' game ball, if used) go to sideline with line-to-gain equipment; and
  - R& LJ (with Home game ball, if used) go to other sideline; meet Captains and escort to center of the field; speaking Captains positioned closest to R
  - R & U face each other; U & BJ stop and remain at the hash marks; HL remains on sideline
  - All other players and coaches remain off the field of play

Section 3 | Coin Toss

❑ Coin Toss Mechanics

- R displays both sides of the coin to all Captains
- Visitors' spokesman chooses "Heads" or "Tails" before coin is flipped; U repeats the Captain's choice for all to hear
- R explains whether coin will be caught or allowed to hit the ground; coin is then flipped
- R declares the winner and offers that team the choice of;
  - ✓ Defer
  - ✓ Receive
  - ✓ Defend a goal
  - ✓ Kick

Section 3 | Coin Toss

❑ Coin Toss Mechanics

- Loser of the coin toss is offered their choice of the remaining options
- Position Captains with their backs to the goal they will defend; give appropriate signals
- Kicking ball given to BJ; other ball returned to its sideline
- As Captains leave the field, all Officials gather to record the results of coin toss; and then moved to their respective kickoff positions

Section 3 | Coin Toss

❑ Second Half Kickoff Options

- It is no longer necessary to meet with the Captains at midfield to determine second-half options; choices may be determined with a sideline conversation with the coaches
- A midfield meeting with the Captains may be held, if needed

❑ Overtime

- The same logistics and mechanics are used for the Overtime Coin Toss except, the options are limited to:

✓ Offense
✓ Defense
✓ Defend a goal

Section 4 | Kick Off / Free Kicks

- **Logistics**
  - All officials assume designated positions for a Free-Kick and count players v/ BJ hands ball to the Kicker; instructs Kicker to signal when ready and wait for R's whistle
  - Positions adjusted if an "on-side kick" is expected
  - Officials raise hand in the air to signal "ready"
  - When Kicker is ready, R sounds whistle to mark the ball ready for the kick

Section 4 | Kick Off / Free Kicks

- **Free-Kick Out Of Bounds (untouched by R)**
  - Covering Official marks spot with penalty flag
  - Nearest Official to R's Coach gets choice of options for penalty enforcement

    NOTE: If R elects to keep the ball, it must be spotted at the inbounds hash mark

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- **Fair Catch / First Touching**
  - Review pertinent rules and mechanics

Section 5 | Dead Ball Intervals

- **Strong Dead Ball Officiating**
  - Player(s) action after the down ends?
  - Crisp ball handling; short, underhand passes; triangle when appropriate
  - Clock status and correct "Next Down?"
  - Note substitutions; count players
    - ✓Offense: R & U
    - ✓Defense: BJ+HL/U

Section 5 | Dead Ball Intervals

- **First Downs**
  - Line-to-gain reached? Close? When in doubt, "Take a look!“
  - LJ primary to stop clock
- **Measurements**
  - BJ / LJ gets new ball from Offense sideline; transfers to LJ prior to measurement
  - BJ secure ball at dead-ball spot; measure before moving ball
  - HL (holding 5—yard intersection clip) brings chains to measure at LJ's 5—yard intersection spot; BJ holds ball
  - U stretches chain for measurement; R decides HL resets chains

Section 5 | Dead Ball Intervals

❑ Between Periods / Halftime

- Between Periods;
  - ✓ If there is no penalty or request for a Coach/Referee Conference, R will signal the end of the period
  - ✓ All Officials come together and record team possession, line of scrimmage, down, line-to-gain (distance), clip location and ball location relative to hash marks
  - ✓ U (with ball) and R will move to new spot and hold ball until chains are set
  - ✓ HL coordinates movement of chains; after chains are set and HL & U confirm new spot, ball is spotted
  - ✓ U & BJ monitor team huddles; at 45 seconds, Teams are notified to return to the field

Section 5 | Dead Ball Intervals

❑ Between Periods / Halftime

- Halftime
  - ✓ If there is no penalty or request for a Coach/Referee Conference, R will signal the end of the half
  - ✓ All Officials come together and wait for Teams to leave the field; when clear, R will start the halftime clock

Section 6 | Scrimmage Plays

- **General**
  - Pre & Post Snap;
  - Positioning;
  - Keys;
  - Motion
  - Coverage;
- Running Plays
  - Coverage
  - Out-of-Bounds
  - Blocks

Section 6 | Scrimmage Plays

- **Passing Plays**
  - Coverage
  - Pass Eligibility
  - Backward Passes
  - Illegal Passes
  - Passes — Inside & Underneath
  - Pass Interference

Section 6 | Scrimmage Plays

- ❑ **Goal Line / End Line Plays**
- ❑ **Fumbles**
- ❑ **See the Ball!!**
- ❑ **Force / Momentum**

Section 7 | Scrimmage Kicks

- **Punts**
  - Coverage
  - Out-of-Bounds
  - First Touching
  - Fair Catch End Zone
  - PSK Fouls

Section 7 | Scrimmage Kicks

- **Scoring Kicks**
  - Coverage
  - Goal Line
  - End Line
  - Live Ball / Dead Ball

Section 8 | Disqualification Mechanics (Ejection)

- ❑ **Crew Conference**
  - Ensure you have all the facts, perspectives and correct player(s)
- ❑ **Coach Conference**
  - Rand Ejecting Official (or R and Wing Official, if R ejects) escort player(s) to sideline

Section 9 | Final Thoughts

❑Work / Communicate as a Team

- Report only what you know / saw
- If you cannot contribute to the Crew discussion, step away and keep players away from the conference

Section 10 | Equipment Check

- ❑ **All Officials**
  - Whistles;
  - Penalty flags
  - Beanbags
  - Down indicators; (HL) chain clip
  - Game cards & pencils
  - Watches
- ❑ **Referee**
  - List of Officials
  - Coin